

Moose

Alces alces



pointed hooves for digging in snow

The world's largest species of deer, the moose lives below the Arctic Circle, inhabiting coniferous and deciduous woodland, swamps, and lakes. In Europe, the moose is also known as the elk, whereas in North America—to add to the confusion—the elk is an entirely different species.

Solitary nomads

Unlike most other deer species, moose are mostly solitary, although females are accompanied by their calves. They do not defend territories, staying on the move all year round. Male moose select habitats that offer the greatest supply of food, while females choose habitats that provide the most cover for them and their young. Moose are diurnal browsers, and may be found cooling off in water during the hottest days of summer while feeding on lily roots and other aquatic plants.

They use their flexible upper lip to browse the freshest leaves and shoots. In winter, when leafy food is in short supply, they will kick away snow to get at moss and lichens underneath, chew on twigs of trees such as poplar and willow, and strip bark from trunks. Their wide hooves help them to walk on soft snow as well as wade through soft-bottomed lakes and swamps.

Male moose rut in the fall, and both sexes bellow to attract a mate. The females choose a mate by sizing up his antlers, which may span over 6 ft (2 m) and have up to 20 points each. Rival males frequently joust for mating rights. Female moose give birth to one or two calves the following summer, which are weaned after six months. A healthy adult moose has little to fear from predators other than humans as it can use its antlers or hooves to defend itself, but bears and wolves predate the much smaller calves.

- ↔ 8–10 ft (2.4–3 m)
- ⚖ 620–1,320 lb (280–600 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Leaves, lichen, water plants, moss, bark
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N. North America, N. Europe, N. and E. Asia

